

CHRIS KIM

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Research and strategy leader with 15+ years building high-performing research teams and shaping product direction through deep customer understanding. Built Match Group's research function from a single researcher to a 20+ person global organization — coaching senior researchers and research managers, growing emerging leaders, and fostering a culture of rigor, growth, and impact across a multi-brand portfolio of 82M+ users in 190+ countries. Deep experience partnering directly with Design, Product, and Engineering executives on ambiguous problems — framing strategy grounded in user understanding and influencing leaders to act on insight. Led foundational AI research that became a durable, org-wide framework for evaluating new AI-driven product concepts. Extensive research into how people curate, represent, and express themselves through content — choosing images, writing personal narratives, and selecting tags that communicate identity — directly relevant to how people create and present themselves through Adobe Express. Known for tailoring narratives across executive, product, and design audiences, and for an empathetic, empowering leadership style that builds confidence and craft in the people I lead.

EXPERIENCE

Career Sabbatical | May 2025 – Present

Intentional pause following 12 years building Match Group's global research function. Pursuing next research and strategy leadership opportunity.

Vice President, Research | **Match Group** May 2013 – May 2025

Tinder, Hinge, Match, Azar and portfolio brands • 82M+ users across 190+ countries • Web and mobile platforms • Multi-brand portfolio serving distinct audiences

Building & Leading High-Performing Research Teams

- Built Match Group's research function from a single researcher to a 20+ person global organization — both hiring senior researchers and research managers externally and growing existing team members into senior and leadership roles, fostering a culture of rigor, growth, and impact
- Managed research managers for 8+ years, providing structured coaching that measurably improved methodology rigor, strategic framing, and executive communication — growing emerging leaders into confident, influential voices in the organization
- Led with an empathetic, empowering style — creating an environment where researchers had ownership over their craft, room to experiment, and support to grow, while maintaining a high bar for research quality
- Established competency frameworks and best practices for study design, synthesis, and presentation that elevated research craft and the function's reputation across the organization

Executive Partnership & Strategic Problem Framing

- Served as a trusted partner to Product, Design, and Engineering executives on ambiguous, undefined problem spaces — leading foundational research to frame the problem itself before solutions were proposed
- Led UX research and strategy for Match Group's innovation lab, embedded in new product workstreams from earliest concept through launch — partnering daily with Product, Design, Engineering, and Strategy to define what to build, for whom, and why, in environments with no existing playbook
- Operated as part of a combined Research & Strategy organization reporting to a Strategy executive — partnering closely with strategists on M&A evaluation, market expansion, and new vertical and product research, translating research findings into specific, implementable strategic recommendations
- Contributed directly to product strategy discussions — bringing customer research and design partnership together to shape product visions, not just validate them after the fact
- Tailored research narratives for executive, product, and design audiences — translating complex findings into clear, actionable recommendations that drove measurable improvements in user and business outcomes

Creative Self-Expression & Identity Research

- Conducted extensive research into how people represent and express themselves through curated content — studying how users selected and arranged photos, wrote personal descriptions, and chose tags representing their interests and personality to construct a compelling representation of who they are
- Research into self-representation directly informed product and design decisions around profile creation tools, prompts, and guidance — helping users create content that authentically and effectively represented their identity
- Studied how users iterated on their self-presentation over time — what content they changed, what worked, and how they used available creative tools (photos, text, tags) to optimize how they came across to others

- Applied this self-expression research lens to AI-assisted profile curation — studying how users responded to AI suggestions for representing themselves, including where AI assistance was welcomed (curation, suggestions) and where users wanted full creative control

AI Research Program

- Led a foundational research program on AI's role across the user experience — mapping where users welcomed AI assistance (content curation, discovery, suggestions) versus where they wanted full human control and authorship
- This research became a durable, reusable framework adopted org-wide to evaluate and prioritize new AI-driven product concepts — directly informing how AI features were introduced and communicated to users across multiple product teams
- Built a systematic AI-augmented research program: integrated AI transcription and synthesis tools (ChatGPT, Claude) into the research workflow, cutting synthesis time by 50% and compressing custom reporting from days to hours — while maintaining methodological rigor and the central role of real participants
- Created a repeatable, prompt-based reporting system mapped to different functional audiences, enabling the team to translate the same underlying research into stakeholder-ready formats for product, design, and executive audiences quickly and consistently

Cross-Functional Facilitation & Strategic Influence

- Acted as an effective facilitator across Product, Design, Research, and Engineering teams at the earliest stages of key initiatives — designing studies that gave competing teams a shared, objective source of truth and turned debate into aligned direction
- Built cross-brand research communities of practice — coordinating with research teams across Hinge, Match, and other portfolio brands to share methods, learnings, and standards, raising the research bar across the organization
- Built a highly respected research function that senior leadership routinely consulted on consequential decisions — including new product launches, market expansion strategy, and acquisition evaluation
- Championed customer-centric thinking across the organization, not just within research — running customer-centricity training sessions for Product Managers, staying closely involved in planning processes to ensure the consumer perspective was represented, and speaking at company all-hands about the value and impact of consumer research
- Built a monthly insights digest for senior leadership — short-form, visually driven, strategy-linked — that became a standing input to product and business planning cycles across the portfolio

Research Strategy for Redesigns & New Audiences

- Defined and led research strategy for Azar's major redesign targeting the US market — a new audience with distinct expectations, conducting heuristics evaluation and UX research that informed language, iconography, and visual design changes, including a redesigned avatar system reflecting the diversity of US users
- Designed and implemented a cross-functional research intake system that surfaced product decisions weeks to months ahead of roadmap commitments — embedding research into strategic planning rather than validating decisions after the fact
- Led research across the full user journey — acquisition, onboarding, content creation, feature adoption, monetization, and retention — for products spanning web and mobile platforms, building a complete picture of how users engaged across the entire experience
- Conducted 250+ studies across the full methodology spectrum — ethnography, in-depth interviews, focus groups, field studies, diary studies, concept and usability testing, and quantitative surveys, driver analysis, and segmentation — selecting the right method for the ambiguity, risk, and decision at hand

EARLIER EXPERIENCE

- Senior Research Analyst, Marketing Evolution (2012–2013) — marketing effectiveness and consumer research
- Client Insights Analyst, IRI (2011–2012) — behavioral and commercial research across CPG and retail clients
- Project Manager, TEGS, Inc. (2010–2011)
- Manager, Research & Analysis, The Nielsen Company (2005–2009) — large-scale behavioral measurement and consumer analytics

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Arts, Political Science • University of California, San Diego • 2004